PRIORITY 11 OF 33 · SCORE 3.3

Energy

Most DOE money goes to national lab operating contractors and nuclear cleanup, which are hard to score from outside. The fraud-prone slice is the fast-growing grant, loan and small business research money from the 2021 infrastructure law and 2022 Inflation Reduction Act: many new recipients, large awards, and thin track records. That is where public award data and the SBA entity checks fit.

INVESTIGATIONS WE PROPOSE

- **DOE-1** Duplicate SBIR/STTR awards. **First prototype.**
- **DOE-2** Thin new recipients of large infrastructure and IRA grants.
- **DOE-3** Loan Programs Office borrowers tied to excluded parties.

EXPOSURE

- $63B in outlays and $141B in budgetary resources in FY2026, swollen by multi-year infrastructure and clean energy appropriations.
- DOE is one of the largest SBIR/STTR funders. GAO found almost 8% of SBIR and STTR awardees had four or more fraud risk indicators and about $445M in possibly duplicative awards across agencies (2024).
- DOE does not report a high-risk improper payment program.

PUBLIC DATA WE USE

- **USAspending and FPDS:** grants, cooperative agreements, contracts and subawards by recipient.
- **SBIR.gov award data:** firm, PI, abstract and agency for every award.
- **DOE Loan Programs Office portfolio** listings.
- **SAM.gov** entity and exclusion records; DOE OIG reports.

HOW WE DETECT IT

1. **Duplicate research awards:** near-identical SBIR abstracts funded by DOE and other agencies (text similarity across SBIR.gov).
2. **Thin recipients, big awards:** new entities winning large grants, shared addresses across "independent" applicants, and pass-through subawards.
3. **Excluded links:** recipients or principal investigators tied to excluded parties or prior settlements.

SCORECARD

Fraud savings identified
● Pending

Phase 1 window
Weeks 9–12
Jan 11, 2027 to Feb 5, 2027

Workstream
Shared screens

FY2026 outlays
$62.7B · budget rank 13

Leads go to
DOE OIG

WHY PRIORITY 11

Exposure	●●●○○
Public data	●●●●○
SBA method fit	●●●●○
Actionability	●●○○○

FIRST PROTOTYPE

A cross-agency SBIR duplicate-award screen covering DOE, NSF, NASA and DoD. It is cheap (one public data set) and serves four briefs at once.

OUR REVIEW, DELIVERED WEEK 12

C2 duplicate-award screen on DOE SBIR/STTR; C3-style check of new infrastructure and IRA grant recipients (thin history, large awards, shared addresses); excluded links for Loan Programs Office borrowers and sponsors.

Every lead goes to an Inspector General or DOJ as a referral package with sources and caveats. Nothing is published.

WHAT WE ASK OF ENERGY

Phase 2 data: Full proposals and budgets, PI current-and-pending support.

What it enables: Duplicate funding at the proposal level.

Access route: Each OIG.

LIMITS

Lab and cleanup contractor costs are not visible below the award level. Duplicate abstracts are leads; some overlap is legitimate.

SOURCES

- GAO-24-105470: SBIR/STTR fraud vulnerabilities (Sept 2024)
- SBIR.gov awards data
- USAspending agency profiles (FY2026 outlays)

Scores and plans are our judgment from public sources. Risk indicators are leads for Inspectors General or DOJ, not accusations.

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